

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

# The Christian Spiritual Reset

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*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,  
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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CHAPTER 6

## Choosing Your Retreat Length and Location

Part One asked you to be honest about your condition. Part Two asks you to be practical about your plans. The two belong together. Many people who genuinely want extended, undistracted time with God never create it, not because they lack desire, but because they never settle the ordinary questions. Four of them can determine whether a retreat happens: when, where, for how long, and what to do with the phone. This chapter will help you decide the length, location, and approximate dates. Chapter 9 will address the phone.

A retreat does not need to be elaborate. It needs to be protected. Everything in this chapter is in service of that one word.

### Choosing your length

This guide is built around three days. If you can take them, take them. The sessions in Part Three are arranged to build gradually, giving you time to engage each stage without unnecessary haste. Day 1 slows you down and helps you begin to release what you are carrying. Day 2 creates space for deeper honesty through lament, confession, and release. Day 3 turns toward listening, identity, and returning. You will not be expected to resolve every grief, confess every failure, or complete forgiveness on a

schedule. If one session requires more time, you may remain with it and leave another for later, and the program builds in walks, meals, and quiet between the heavier sessions. Compressing all of this into a single day is possible, but it is like reading a letter quickly when it deserved to be read slowly.

Three days does not have to mean Friday to Sunday, although that is the most common shape. Some readers will find three consecutive weekdays easier, especially if weekends are the busiest time in their household or ministry. Others may take Saturday, Sunday, and a Monday of leave. The recommended format is three consecutive days without ordinary work between sessions. Continuity helps you move beyond the mental pace of everyday life. If that is genuinely impossible, use the at-home format rather than repeatedly postponing the retreat.

If three consecutive days are out of reach, and for many people they will be, Part Four offers adapted programs:

- **A one-day retreat** covers the essential sessions across approximately eight to ten hours, including meals, walks, rest, and generous breaks. It should not feel like a ten-hour seminar. It is the best alternative for someone who cannot get away overnight.
- **A three-hour reset** is a compressed version for someone who needs to stop now and cannot wait for a day to open up. Think of it as an immediate spiritual pause rather than the full retreat. It is not crisis care or a substitute for professional help.
- **An at-home retreat** spreads seven sessions across eight days, one per day with a rest day, for readers who cannot step away from daily responsibilities at all. This works well for parents of young children and for caregivers. It requires more discipline, because ordinary life keeps interrupting, but it is a real

retreat. Choose the length you can actually protect, not the one that sounds most impressive. A one-day retreat that happens is worth more than a three-day retreat that stays on your list for a year.

One note about going longer. Extended solitude is not automatically better. Three days provides substantial time for prayer, rest, and reflection. If you are considering more than three days, particularly with prolonged silence, fasting, or emotionally intensive exercises, seek guidance from someone experienced in facilitating retreats and consider the concerns raised in Chapter 5. Begin modestly and learn how you respond.

### Choosing your place

Jesus, as Chapter 3 noted, withdrew to ordinary settings: mountains, gardens, wilderness places, and locations away from the crowd. At times a boat carried him away from immediate demands. You do not need a retreat centre, and you should not let the lack of one stop you. But the place does matter, because some places make it much harder to be quiet than others. Here is an overview, followed by notes on each.

| Location         | Main advantage          | Main challenge                  | Best suited for              |
|------------------|-------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------|
| Home alone       | Free and familiar       | Chores and digital distraction  | One-day or three-day retreat |
| Home with others | Accessible              | Frequent interruption           | At-home format               |
| Borrowed home    | Affordable and separate | Privacy and access arrangements | One-day or three-day retreat |
| Church building  | Quiet and inexpensive   | Security and interruptions      | Day retreat                  |

| Location            | Main advantage             | Main challenge                 | Best suited for                                    |
|---------------------|----------------------------|--------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Retreat centre      | Purpose-built environment  | Cost and travel                | First three-day retreat                            |
| Hotel or guesthouse | Privacy and availability   | Phone, television, and expense | One-day or three-day retreat                       |
| Outdoors            | Natural quiet and movement | Weather and safety             | Individual sessions, not usually the whole retreat |

**Your own home, alone.** If you live alone, or your household can be away for the period, home is free, familiar, and requires no travel. The disadvantage is that home is full of unfinished work: the laundry, the inbox, the project on the table, the neighbour who knocks. It takes real discipline to treat your own home as a retreat. If you choose it, set up one room as the retreat space, close the doors on the rest, and follow the digital boundary in Chapter 9 carefully.

**Your own home, with the household present.** This is the hardest option and the one many parents and caregivers will have to use. It works best in the at-home format, with sessions early in the morning or after the children are asleep, and it works only if the other adults in the house understand what you are doing and agree to protect the time. Be realistic. You will be interrupted. Chapter 3 told you what to do about that.

**A borrowed home or empty flat.** A relative's house while they are away, a friend's cabin, a church member's guest room. This is often the best option: free or cheap, quiet, and free of your own unfinished business. Ask; people are usually glad to help. Confirm who may enter, whether you will have genuine privacy, and whether the property is safe and suitable for an overnight stay.

**A church building.** Many churches sit empty on weekdays and have a room, a chapel, or a hall you could use for a day. Ask your pastor. If you are a pastor, ask a colleague at a different church, so that you are not in the building where everyone can find you. Confirm access, closing procedures, alarms, toilets, heating or cooling, and whether remaining alone in the building is permitted. At least one responsible person should know when you arrive and leave.

**A retreat centre, monastery, or guesthouse.** Many Christian retreat centres and religious communities offer simple rooms for personal retreats at modest cost, sometimes with meals included. These are purpose-built for silence. Some offer access to a trained spiritual director or retreat guide; ask about the person's training, theological approach, confidentiality, and safeguarding practices before arranging a meeting. The cost varies widely by country. If it is within your means, this is a very good choice for a first three-day retreat, because the environment does much of the protecting for you.

**A hotel or guesthouse.** A simple hotel away from home can work well if you are disciplined about the television and the phone. Choose a legitimate property with secure access, reliable staff, and a location where you feel safe. Tell your designated contact where you are staying, but do not share your location publicly. You are not there for the amenities.

**Outdoors.** A park, a beach, a hillside, a garden. Scripture is full of people who met God outside; Isaac "went out to meditate in the field toward evening" (Genesis 24:63), and Jesus prayed on mountains. The outdoors is excellent for parts of a retreat, particularly the walking and silence exercises, but it is rarely practical as the sole location for three days. Combine it with one of the options above. And be sensible: tell someone where you are going, avoid isolated places you do not know, and check the

weather, daylight, accessibility, transport, water, and phone coverage. Solitude does not require placing yourself beyond the reach of help.

### **What to look for in any location**

Whichever option you choose, test it against these seven questions.

1. **Can I have protected time here?** Complete freedom from demands is ideal. In an at-home format, the question is whether you can establish reliable blocks of time when someone else handles ordinary needs.
2. **Does this place help me feel sufficiently safe and settled?** Avoid locations that trigger distress, traumatic memories, or a persistent sense of danger, especially if you will be alone.
3. **Can I sleep well here?** Rest is part of the retreat, not a break from it. Elijah slept before God spoke.
4. **Can I eat simply here?** You do not want to spend the retreat cooking or hunting for food. Chapter 11 will cover this in more detail.
5. **Can I control my connectivity without losing access to help?** Reliable reception with the phone on Do Not Disturb or airplane mode may be safer than travelling somewhere with no signal. Keep emergency calling available where possible.
6. **Can this place support my physical needs?** Consider accessibility, medication storage, bathroom access, seating, temperature, dietary needs, transportation, and proximity to appropriate help. A retreat should not require you to ignore your body in order to care for your soul.
7. **Can I afford it without stress?** A retreat that puts you in debt or causes tension at home has already undermined its purpose. Choose the most affordable option that is safe,

practical, and sufficiently supportive. More expensive does not mean more spiritual or more effective. Cost deserves one more word. Some readers will feel that a proper retreat requires a proper retreat centre and, since they cannot afford one, will not go at all. That is exactly the situation this book was written to address. The most important elements of a retreat, unhurried time, honesty before God, Scripture, and silence, are free. Everything else is helpful but optional.

## Timing

Two practical notes about when.

First, if possible, reduce unnecessary demands for a day or two before the retreat. Many readers will not have that option, and some will arrive exhausted. If that is you, allow yourself to sleep. Resting through part of the first day does not mean you have wasted it or failed to follow the program.

Second, try not to schedule anything demanding for the day immediately after. Returning straight to a heavy schedule can make it harder to process and carry forward what became clear during the retreat. Part Five will help you with re-entry, but the simplest help is a soft landing on the calendar.

## Decide

Take a few minutes now and write down:

1. **Length:** three days, one day, three hours, or an eight-day at-home retreat. If three days, which three?
2. **Location:** which of the options above, and specifically where. If you need to ask someone, write down whom and when you will ask.

3. **The seven questions:** go through them for your chosen place. Any that you answered "no" to need a solution or a different place.
4. **Dates:** the retreat itself, plus a softer day before and after if you can arrange it. If you cannot complete this list yet, that is fine. But before continuing, I strongly encourage you to choose at least a format and a target month. A tentative plan can be adjusted; an undefined intention is easy to postpone.